Case Study Three

My Primary School is at the National Waterfront Museum, Swansea

An outward-looking primary school joined forces with a popular museum on Swansea's scenic waterfront to offer their youngest pupils a memorable five weeks of activities.

Brimming with enthusiasm for their new home, the children became more independent and confident. Their teachers used the museum's artefacts and activities to experiment, while the museum gained an invaluable insight into how this age group engages with its resources.

The partners:

St Thomas Community Primary School
Located in the east of Swansea, St Thomas has over 350 pupils. It nurtures close links with parents, families and the community, offering facilities such as the library, community rooms and a multi-purpose hall, all used by local groups.

The National Waterfront Museum
Housed in an original waterfront warehouse linked to a new, ultra-modern slate and glass building, this popular museum tells the story of Welsh industry and innovation. It presents industrial and maritime heritage through cutting-edge, interactive technology as well as more traditional displays

With its thriving educational programme, the museum is the largest provider of learning outside the classroom in Wales, hosting around 15,500 school visits every year.

Dates of project:
22 February 2016 – 24 March 2016
- 1st project

16 May 2016 – 24 June 2016
- 2nd project

Number of pupils and age of pupils involved:
!st project: 27 four and five year olds (reception class)
2nd project: 24 four and five year olds (reception class)

School team:
Laura Luxton, class teacher (first project)
Claire Stallwood, class teacher (second project)
Russel Dwyer, Head Teacher

National Waterfront Museum team:
Leisa Bryant, Senior Learning Participation and Interpretation Officer
Nia Williams, Head of Learning, Participation and Interpretation

"The long-term impact of this project will be for us to develop deeper engagement opportunities

with local schools."
Nia Williams, National Waterfront Museum

What happened during the project?

Class teacher Laura Luxton planned her teaching sessions around the themes of activities and workshops offered by the museum, liaising closely with learning officer Leisa Bryant.

Themes included:

- Creatures of the sea: A team of marine biologists from Swansea University brought fish, snails and crabs from their trawl and encouraged the children to handle them and talk about their features.
- Toys: Parents were invited to come along and learn with their children at a workshop led by a curator.
- Pirate Day: Children and teachers dressed up as pirates, working with an actor at the museum who talked to them about the marina, boats and life at sea.

A key part of the museum sessions were the reading, writing and numeracy activities that would usually take place in school. The class also visited the leisure centre opposite the museum for PE lessons and the local art gallery hosted a day of creative activities for the group.

"You could see the benefits of them reading words on displays, talking about exhibitions whilst learning about their heritage."
Laura Luxton, teacher

Which activities were particularly memorable?

Inspired by the Robin Goch - A costumed actor played the role of Charles Horace Watkins who built the Robin Goch monoplane hanging from the ceiling in one of the museum's atria. He told the fable of Icarus and discussed flight and the basic principles of aircraft design. This session sparked the children's imaginations by involving them as players in the story and the Robin Goch became a favourite theme throughout the project..

Benefits of the project

National Waterfront Museum

- Increased understanding of how a younger age group engages with its collections and activities
- A chance to push the boundaries of learning activities and experiment more with museum spaces
- A commitment to forging stronger relationships with local schools
- Reaching local families who have never visited the museum.

"It has added to our practice in trying to make our sessions more participative and memorable for every audience."
Leisa Bryant, National Waterfront Museum

St Thomas Community Primary School

- Confidence gained from teaching the curriculum outside of the classroom
- The opportunity to explore the museum and its artefacts in much greater depth
- Experimenting with a variety of themes and activities
- Benefiting from the museum's pedagogical approach of providing a more sensory experience for children by using objects in teaching sessions.

"I suppose the biggest surprise that we have had from the project is how smoothly it's actually operated."
Russel Dwyer, Head Teacher

Children

- Development of vocabulary and speaking skills
- Increased independence eg with personal skills: toileting, organisation, preparation and separation from their parents in the morning.
- Greater bonding between the children
- Increased social skills and better manners.

"We saw children who had barely spoken in school become animated and vocal, challenging themselves, communicating with their peers and displaying such a fabulous range of emotions."
Laura Luxton, class teacher

What were the main challenges?

Travel: the class had to travel to and from the school at the start and end of each day which was very tiring for the children.

Resources: the teaching staff had to work without the usual teaching tools and the 'safety net' of being in the school building.